

THE CURSE OF MACBETH

One of the “weird sisters” wore this costume in a recent production of *Macbeth*. The black magic in the play has led to a belief among superstitious actors that *Macbeth* is cursed. There are many stories of accidents during productions. According to the 17th-century writer John Aubrey, bad luck followed the play from its first performance, when the boy playing Lady Macbeth fell sick and died. Actors try to beat the curse by never mentioning the play’s title, calling it “the Scottish play” instead.

This costume was used in a Royal Shakespeare production of *Macbeth*

Actors say it is bad luck to wear costumes from *Macbeth* in any other production

The dark colors of the costume reflect the description by Shakespeare of the ugly “midnight hags”

Dress made of torn strips of cotton

Achilles drags Hector’s body behind his chariot

Hector’s horrified parents watch from Troy

A PROBLEM OF STYLE

This ancient Roman lamp shows a scene from the Trojan war, the subject of Shakespeare’s *Troilus and Cressida*, one of his three “problem plays.” Critics use this term because they are unable to fit the plays into the usual categories of comedy or tragedy. *All’s Well That Ends Well*, *Measure for Measure*, and *Troilus and Cressida* share many features of comedy, but they are also dark and gloomy in mood. *Troilus and Cressida* ends with the Trojan Hector, killed by Achilles, “at the murderer’s horse’s tail, in beastly sort, dragg’d through the shameful field.”